

Moonsea Rising - 20240224

Elsewhere

Gozer : The Choice is made!

Dr. Peter Venkman : Whoa! Ho! Ho! Whoa-oo!

Gozer : The Traveller has come!

Dr. Peter Venkman : Nobody choosed anything!

[turns to Egon]

Dr. Peter Venkman : Did you choose anything?

Dr. Egon Spengler : No.

Dr. Peter Venkman : [to Winston] Did YOU?

Winston Zeddemore : My mind is totally blank.

Dr. Peter Venkman : I didn't choose anything...

[long pause, Peter, Egon and Winston all look at Ray]

Dr. Raymond Stantz : I couldn't help it. It just popped in there.

Dr. Peter Venkman : [angrily] What? WHAT "just popped in there?"

Dr. Raymond Stantz : I... I... I tried to think...

Dr. Egon Spengler : LOOK!

[they all look over one side of the roof]

Dr. Raymond Stantz : No! It CAN'T be!

Dr. Peter Venkman : What is it?

Dr. Raymond Stantz : It CAN'T be!

Dr. Peter Venkman : What did you DO, Ray?

Winston Zeddemore : Oh, shit!

[they all see a giant cubic white head topped with a sailor hat, Peter looks at Ray]

Dr. Raymond Stantz : [somberly] It's the Stay Puft Marshmallow Man.

The Traveller

As the doors slam shut, separating Beitris from the others, the otherworldly figures speaks to the party's minds.

"One shall ask; another shall pay."

Coming from the walls in a number of places are creatures which seem to be made of the same substance of the walls itself. Suddenly, they all freeze in place, as Beitris appears in the room, standing on the golden etched circle opposite the one holding the corpse of Argens Brule.

She looks at the entity and says, "thank you." It looks at her and says, "ask, but be prepared to pay." She finds herself unable to will herself to leave the circle. Harken calls out to her to hold her tongue, as she kneels to inspect the circle restraining her. While she doesn't recognize the words, she recognizes the script as thalassic.

Harken psychically messages the nearest scion asking about the effects of the disc. He is somewhat hysterical, and only begs for help. He attempts to contact several of the other scions, but they are scared, cryptic, and only sure that it's time to go. Taevyn rushes around the orc corpses to Beitris, attempting to remove her from the circle.

As he moves to touch her, a bolt of corruscating light lashes from the entity and burns his hand.

Lirael has been trying to discern what is going here. The entity looks like it might be related to some kind of ancient, aquatic deity. The creatures in the walls appear to be wall wights, undead tomb guardians.

At Taevyn's request, she wends her way up to look at the circle. The thylassic is very ancient, and she only recognizes the concept of "fate" and "bundle" which she relays to Beitris with a caution.

Examining the altar, Taevyn and Lennox find a sacrificial dagger which has been somewhat recently used, as well as a ledger of some kind, indecipherable to them. The last name is General Siv Tuskclaw. The name at the top of the page is Fyndelion Silverweave.

As Taevyn starts trying to free the scions, Lennox goes to look at Argens Brule. He has three burns that look much like worse versions of the one Taevyn is now sporting.

Lirael tells Taevyn to ask Calman Larigan if he knows what Argens asked for. He panics and immediately tries to flee the room. Lirael tells him to remember his station and die, if he must, like a man. He pulls himself together and tells them Argens didn't ask for anything, but was the sacrifice for the orcish general.

As Taevyn and Lennox finish freeing the scions, they start collecting themselves, but, other than Calman Larigan, don't seem quite as terrified of their current predicament.

Harken moves forward, his mind calculating his options. He asks the entity, "what is the point of these questions?" It responds, "a question is asked, and a promise is fulfilled."

A bolt of radiant light strikes Beitris, burning her badly. Benvolio Beregan pipes up that the general spent all the orcs on the floor asking questions. He says the general disappeared when the chest

was summoned. Lennox wanders over to the chest and opens it. Inside are enough bones to make a large humanoid, floating in blood. Lennox is immediately sickened.

Based on Benvolio's remarks that if both discs are occupied, the asker is not the one who pays the price. Lennox thinks about this, and mounts the second the disc. As Lennox looks to be about to ask something, Beitris stops him, and suggests the brainstorm before asking questions. Lirael posits that not all requests are questions, and that asking for a boon or property could also be "asking". Benvolio suggests that she's on track.

After thinking about her family's history, Beitris turns to the entity and demands it, "let all living creatures in the temple return to the surface unharmed." A beam of light of strikes Lennox, and they all hear the entity say, "granted." She is able to leave her circle, but Lennox is not, and the door remains closed. As the party debates the best way out, Benvolio and Kara Caladra pipe up with more info. Benvolio tells them that the orc general didn't seem to be getting the results he wanted until he provided a blood sacrifice. Kara tells them that the general asked to be the most dangerous and feared thing in the Moonsea Region.

Taevyn notices that the passage behind the entity opens up into a narrow passageway. When he goes to investigate, he is struck by more radiant damage. He tells everyone there's a man down the passage, though he doesn't respond to calls. As Beitris and Harken try to formulate a strategy, she offers a prayer to Lathander. The entity turns red during this prayer, and the sound of clashing steel can be heard in the distance. Harken tells her to try that again and see if Lennox can step off his circle.

Taevyn, meanwhile, finds a secret passage that leads towards where he saw the man. He proceeds down, with Lirael following him, at a distance. Around the corner, they find a man in a hut made of mist. He dismisses his hut and speaks to them in a language they don't understand, but then casts comprehend languages.

The man tells Taevyn, in response to questioning, that the entity gave him eternal life, but he may not leave with it. She asks him if he's affiliated with the entity's god -- he is not -- and how long he's be there. He asks her if Fentia ever became a major power.

Lirael tells him Fentia vanished at least seven centuries prior. Mintiper Moonsilver, as he tells them his name is in response to Taevyn's question. After asking him more about the orcs, he tells them that the dagger "registers" the asker, and that the payment must have noble blood.

Lirael's heart sinks at that. "Lots," she thinks, "we'll have to draw lots." Mintiper offers them his treasure, a sharp spear, a chest full of silver, and a portable hole. She and Taevyn rejoin the others, and share Mintiper's intelligence. Lirael tells them they should draw lots, but Harken rather uncharacteristically tells them that he does have noble blood, and he's probably the healthiest to still stand for it.

Taevyn tries to fetch the dagger from the altar, but the wall wights immediately move away from the wall. He drops it back down, and looks to Lennox for more ideas. Lennox draws his own dagger, cuts his hand, and tosses the dagger to Taevyn. Taevyn smears the blood from Lennox' dagger to the one on the altar, and uses it to inscribe Lennox' name in the book.

As Harken steps onto the other circle, the entity starts to glow, its tentacles waving. Mintiper chirps from the back room, "oh, this is gonna be good! Here we go!" Harken narrows his eyes at

the ancient man's enthusiasm.

Speaking slowly, Lennox asks that, "all living creatures within this room, be allowed to walk out of this temple complex without harm, loss of stuff, and that it be now."

A beam of radiance bathes Harken in burning light. He drops to his knees, screaming, as the light burns him, though he is not killed. A door opens in the corner, revealing a black starfield with a suspicious lack of visible ground. The door through which they entered remains securely closed.

As the door starts to close, Beitris yells for everyone to run through the door. She and Taevyn bolt through, but find themselves, expectedly, in the depths of space. Taevyn manages to catch the doorframe, but Beitris isn't so lucky. Muttering, Lirael lashes out with a gouging claw, snagging the other woman, but cutting her substantially in the process.

Harken feels like they're secure enough, that they should take a long rest and try again healed up in the morning. Lirael casts detect magic on the chest, which resonates with every school of magic, and might well be the most dangerous, as the orc general wished to become. She resolves to attempt attunement as part of her daily preparation.

After her daily communion, Betriss heals herself and Harken. The entity seems unaffected by the use of Lathandrite divinity in its vicinity.

Lirael's attunement to Tuskclaw's Chest brings a surge of power, and thoughts of dominance and control. However, Tuskclaw's soul will help her in exchange for some control. She believes she can return them to Melvaunt, at some cost. She asks Lennox and Taevyn to move the artifact into the middle of the room, and gather everyone around it. They do, and Taevyn picks up Argens' corpse, saying he doesn't deserve to be left behind.

As Lirael prepares to transport them, Beitris tries to surreptitiously cast protection from evil. Lirael notices, as the protection spell sears her, and grasping the power of the chest, she immediately counters the spell.

Angrily, she rounds on Beitris, demanding an explanation. A defensive Beitris explains that it was protection against evil. Lirael rather snidely informs her that the chest is clearly evil, and if she could refrain while she's attempting to save them all, that would be best.

Darkly muttering, she turns back to the chest, her hands caressing its dark wood. Reality wavers, and they find themselves back in the warehouse in Melvaunt they were in with Edric.

Everyone notices that Lirael has fallen to her knees, her hand grasping the femur on the lid with a white-knuckled grip. Wheezing and gasping, she struggles to stand.